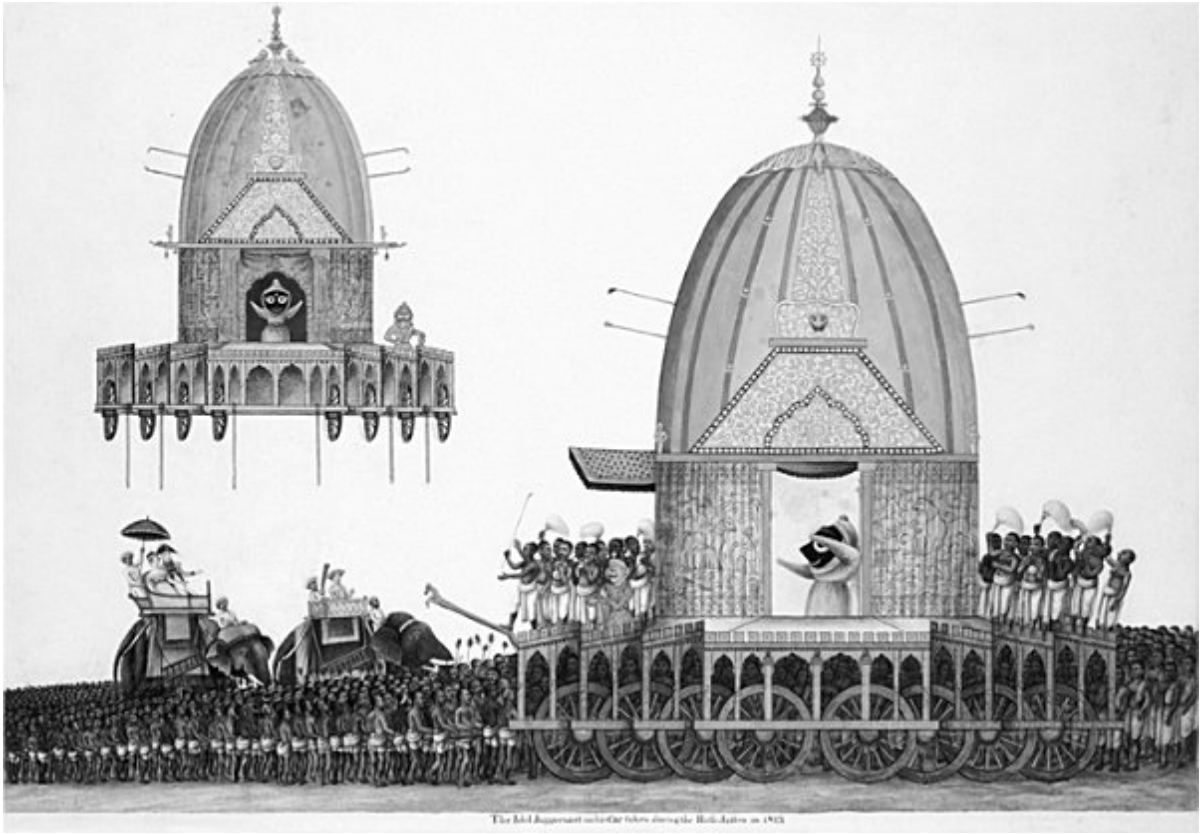


A watercolour of the Jagannath procession in Puri in 1820, showing the ‘lord of the universe’ being drawn through the street in his sixteen-wheeled *ratha* attended by the British Commissioner Andrew Stirling, shown seated with his wife on an elephant (far left).

Today such acts of self-harm are even less infrequent but the cult of Jagannath continues to fascinate scholars, and with good reason, because the Jagannath temple at Puri and its contents do have a quite extraordinary history.

Recent excavations at Udayagiri and Ratnagiri in the hills north-west of Cuttack have revealed a number of monastic sites where Buddhism continued to be practised as late as the twelfth century. As for the temple city of Bhubaneshwar, visitors who tour these restored temples today can hardly imagine how utterly different the scene was when the EICo took over the region. The entire temple area had been largely abandoned following the desecrations inflicted by the raider Baki Khan in the 1640s, and all but the central Lingaraja temple – described by James Fergusson as ‘the